

The Reality Drift Template: How Systems Keep Working While Losing Contact With Reality

A reusable diagnostic pattern for AI systems, institutions, language, media, metrics, and culture.

Part of the Reality Drift framework by A. Jacobs

Core Definition

The Reality Drift Template describes a recurring pattern in which a system keeps functioning while gradually losing contact with the reality it was built to represent. It is a reusable structure for recognizing the same sequence across different systems, rather than treating each case as isolated.

The pattern usually begins before anything looks broken. The surface remains stable enough to preserve trust, but the underlying reference point starts to weaken.

Over time, the system becomes more organized around its own categories, incentives, procedures, and internal logic than the reality those structures were meant to track. Because it still appears coherent and functional, continued operation gets mistaken for alignment.

Reality Drift names the condition where continued function masks a weakening relationship to reality.

Stages of Reality Drift

1. Surface Continuity

Reality Drift begins with surface continuity. The system still appears to work, which makes drift difficult to recognize. It continues producing outputs, following procedures, generating measurements, or performing the role people expect from it.

Surface continuity creates the illusion of stability. People assume that if something still operates, it must still be serving its original purpose. But operation and alignment are not the same.

2. Reference Decay

The second stage is reference decay. This is where the system's representation stops tracking the underlying condition cleanly. The representation may still appear useful, but its relationship to the original referent becomes less reliable.

Reference decay often happens because systems need simplified representations in order to operate. Reality gets converted into scores, dashboards, categories, incentives, benchmarks, policies, summaries, and stories. These abstractions make complexity manageable, but once the system begins organizing itself around them, they can slowly replace the thing they were meant to represent.

At this stage, the system starts responding more to its own map than to the territory.

3. Local Compensation

The third stage is local compensation. Once drift begins, the system is usually kept alive through patches to the visible problem. Exceptions, workarounds, secondary metrics, and manual corrections can preserve function without restoring contact with reality.

These adjustments can be reasonable on their own. Over time, though, the system becomes dependent on compensations that preserve motion without correcting the underlying loss of reference. It survives by becoming more complicated, but not more grounded.

4. Normalization

The fourth stage is normalization. After enough time, the distorted state starts to feel ordinary. What began as a workaround becomes part of the process, what began as a proxy becomes treated as the target, and what once felt degraded becomes accepted as normal.

People may still complain, but they begin adapting to the system's assumptions. They learn how to move through the distortion rather than questioning why the distortion exists.

Once that happens, drift becomes the background condition inside which decisions are made.

5. Delayed Recognition

The final stage is delayed recognition. The problem becomes obvious only after the costs are hard to ignore.

This is why drift is often recognized late. The system kept working, so people assumed it was still grounded. Only later does it become clear that the connection to reality had been weakening for a long time.

The Difference Between Failure and Drift

Ordinary failure breaks the surface. Reality Drift preserves it.

The system keeps operating, which makes the problem harder to detect. What looks like stability may actually be a slow loss of contact with the reality the system was built to represent.

That is why continued function can be misleading. The surface can remain coherent, useful, and familiar while the grounding underneath weakens.

Keywords: *Reality Drift, Reality Drift Template, surface continuity, reference decay, local compensation, normalization, delayed recognition, coherence without contact, continued operation without alignment, representation replacing reality, systems losing contact with reality, proxy drift, metric drift, institutional drift, AI drift, semantic drift, grounding failure, constraint collapse, synthetic realness, optimization trap, semantic fidelity, how systems keep working while losing contact with reality, why functioning systems become misaligned, how metrics lose contact with reality, why AI outputs sound right but lose grounding, and how proxies replace reality*

Core Framework and Sources

- [Substack \(Articles\)](#)
- [GitHub \(Full Library\)](#)
- [DOI \(Research Paper\)](#)
- [Glossary & Definition](#)